Ioana **Frîncu**

AI R&D Product Manager • AI System Evaluation • AI Infra

Brussels, Belgium · Willing to relocate

(+32) 456390234 | f_ioana@tuta.com | flifenstein.com | flifenstein | frincui | Ioana Frincu

"Something will go wrong. The question is whether you measured it."

Summary

My premise is simple: AI must be evaluated on its deployment reality — real hardware, real serving stacks, real concurrency. At imec's top AI team, I lead **aistack**, a neutral **system-level benchmark for general-purpose AI**, deciding what each study measures (models, agent harness, infrastructure) and owning the findings through to publication. Our first study found **benchmark scores and deployed behaviour diverge under production load**; that gap is the work I want to focus on. I got here as the translator between engineering and strategy: production inference at OpenChip, programme delivery at Microsoft's AI for Good Lab, and **LLM evaluation** research.

Work Experience

imec · aistack

Ghent, Belgium

AI R&D Product Manager — *May 2026 – Present*

- Leading product strategy and benchmark methodology for aistack.
- Published aistack's first study, *"How many devs can you fit on a GPU?"* — coding agents on **self-hosted open-weight models** (Qwen, DeepSeek, GLM, Kimi) on **H200/B200-class hardware** vs. frontier APIs; found **task resolution shifts materially with serving configuration and concurrency** (aistack.imec-int.com/blog/gpu-self-hosting).
- Operating across product, industry engagement, and public communication in a **16-person startup-style AI R&D team** inside imec.

OpenChip

Ghent, Belgium

AI Platform Product Owner — *Nov. 2025 – Apr. 2026*

- Owned product **Booster**, a **multi-tenant LLM inference platform** on **KServe and vLLM**. Served as central decision-maker for a team of 6 senior engineers, closing architecture decisions autonomously including **shared vs. unique tenant identity** in multi-tenant deployments.
- Unblocked a 2-week beta-scope deadlock by shipping a working **Claude Code prototype** for Booster in **under two days**, forcing concrete product decisions. Separately introduced Agile ceremonies from week two — the team had none.

Microsoft

Brussels / Remote

Product Management Intern — AI for Good Lab — *Mar. 2025 – Nov. 2025*

- End-to-end launch of **LINGUA**, a Microsoft AI4G Lab grant program funding **open-licensed datasets** for **underrepresented European languages**; **11 projects** selected across **16 languages** and **10 countries**.
- Shipped an internal AI storytelling tool built to streamline research-to-impact reporting across lab projects.
- Engaged with Microsoft's **Brussels EU policy office** on regulatory touchpoints for the lab's European initiatives.

Twipe Digital Publishing

Leuven, Belgium

Jr. Product Owner — *Oct. 2023 – Mar. 2025*

- Shipped a multi-title app feature on a **21-person-day budget** by owning the full delivery chain: stack migration, UX, release monitoring, and post-release triage across teams.
- Introduced **automated E2E testing** to replace manual QA; owned all platform releases across mobile and web and drove **compliance-critical** technical deadlines ahead of quarter.

Research & AI Safety

Iris.AI (in collaboration with Aalto University)

Remote

Research Intern — NLP / LLM Evaluation

Feb. 2023 – Sep. 2023

- Designed and ran a **human-subject evaluation study** comparing **soft vs. hard prompt-tuning** for LLM-generated scientific abstracts. Built the study protocol, recruited participants, and analysed **qualitative and quantitative measures** of output utility. Thesis (Aalto repository).

AI Safety & Community

Courses & Community Engagement

2025 – Present

- **BlueDot Technical AI Safety** (May 2026). **BlueDot AGI Strategy** (Feb. 2026). **Turing AI Ethics** (Feb. 2026).
- Active member of **AGI Collective Brussels** & **EA Belgium**.
- Founding Ambassador, **Women in AI Belgium** (2026) — launched the Belgian chapter; stepped back in May to focus on AI safety coursework and writing.
- Writing at flifenstein.com.

Skills

Evaluation	Agentic benchmark design, system-level evaluation, human–AI evaluation methodology, statistical analysis (R)
Infrastructure	LLM inference & serving (vLLM, KServe), GPU infrastructure (H200/B200-class), Kubernetes, Docker
Product	Product strategy, 0-to-1 scoping, roadmap & prioritization, technical specs, stakeholder alignment, Agile
Engineering	Python, SQL, R, JavaScript & TypeScript, React, TailwindCSS
Responsible AI	EU AI Act literacy, RAI review processes, AI ethics frameworks
Languages	English (C2), Romanian (C2), Dutch (B2), French (A2)

Education

EIT Digital Master School

Netherlands & Finland

MSc, Human–Computer Interaction & Design — Double Degree

Sep. 2021 – Sep. 2023

- **University of Twente** (Y1) + **Aalto University** (Y2). Minor in Innovation & Entrepreneurship.
- Technical coursework: **Machine Learning**, **NLP**, Conversational Agents, Speech Processing, Affective Computing, Product Management, Computer Ethics.
- Thesis: "In Search of the Perfect Prompt" — **soft vs. hard prompt-tuning evaluation** for LLM outputs.

University of Twente

Netherlands

BSc, Communication Science

Sep. 2017 – Sep. 2021

- Coursework: **statistics & R**, persuasive technology, UX research methods.